ambassadors that requested a meeting with the then foreign minister Rosenthal. During the meeting, I stressed that we should counter populism wherever it appears and that it is therefore important for the government to speak up about European values. Nothing came as a result of the meeting. But this example – years before the migration crisis of 2015, in which it was Eastern Europe that was not a welcoming host – showed the centrality of the migration issues, and the underlying cultural and philosophical questions. It also showed that populism and xenophobia are not limited to former Communist lands. They have been a part and parcel of society in France (Le Pen's RN and Mélenchon's La France Insoumise – as the election of 2022 showed), the Netherlands (Geert Wilders and perhaps even more the Forum for Democracy), Italy (Forza Italia, Lega and increasingly the Brothers of Italy), Sweden (Sweden Democrats), Austria (Freedom Party) and Germany (AdF and Die Linke), not to mention the United States. Also, Gideon Rachman in his book on 'strongmen' around the world unashamedly lists Boris Johnson, former UK Prime Minister, among the likes of Putin, Erdogan, Xi Jinping, Modi, Orbán, Kaczyński, Trump and Duterte, saying that 'in a very English way, he had introduced important elements of the strongman style of politics into Britain. He had shown a willingness to break both domestic and international law. He had demonised opponents as elitist enemies of the people.' In Rachman's view, '[g]iven Britain's position as one of the world's oldest democracies, the election of a populist rule-breaker as UK Prime Minister marked a significant shift in European and world politics.'[123] Anne Applebaum affirms too that this is not an Eastern European problem only, stressing that populism in Eastern Europe is a phenomenon of the last decade.[124]

To be fair, Western European countries are well equipped to face these political movements with an array of long-established institutions, well-developed and plural civil society organisations and quality independent media. All these do not have the same strength and tradition in Eastern Europe, so the danger to the social fabric is much greater. Still, the fact that in the West such political parties have been thriving despite this array of institutions is no less troubling. In fact, it raises doubts about their strength too.

In all these (and other) countries the increasingly weak political mainstream has been fighting hard to fend off populism and an anti-